# Milwaukee Police Department

*Patrol Staffing Review: Matching Shift Schedules to Call Volume*

## Executive Summary & Problem Statement

This brief looks at 112,283 police incident records across Milwaukee to solve the problem of current patrol schedules not matching when people actually call for help.

Right now, patrol officers are spread mostly evenly across three standard shifts. However, call volume changes dramatically throughout the day and year. Officers on the evening shift are overwhelmed with calls, while late-night officers face a massive surge in calls right around midnight.

To fix this problem without hiring more staff or increasing costs, there are three simple changes that could be made:

1. Create an overlapping “Power Shift” (6:00 PM - 2:00 AM) to put extra officers on the street during the busiest hours.
2. Rebalance shift staffing so more officers work when call volume is highest.
3. Use focused patrols and better street lighting in peak crime hotspots to prevent crime before it happens.

## Shift Workload & Daily Demand Analysis

Looking at all 112,283 calls, the workload drops heavily on afternoon and night officers:

| Operational Shift | Hours | Total Calls | Share of Calls (%) |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1st Shift (Day) | 8:00 AM - 4:00 PM | 32,225 | 28.7% |
| 2nd Shift (Evening) | 4:00 PM - Midnight | 46,261 | 41.2% |
| 3rd Shift (Night) | Midnight - 8:00 AM | 33,797 | 30.1% |

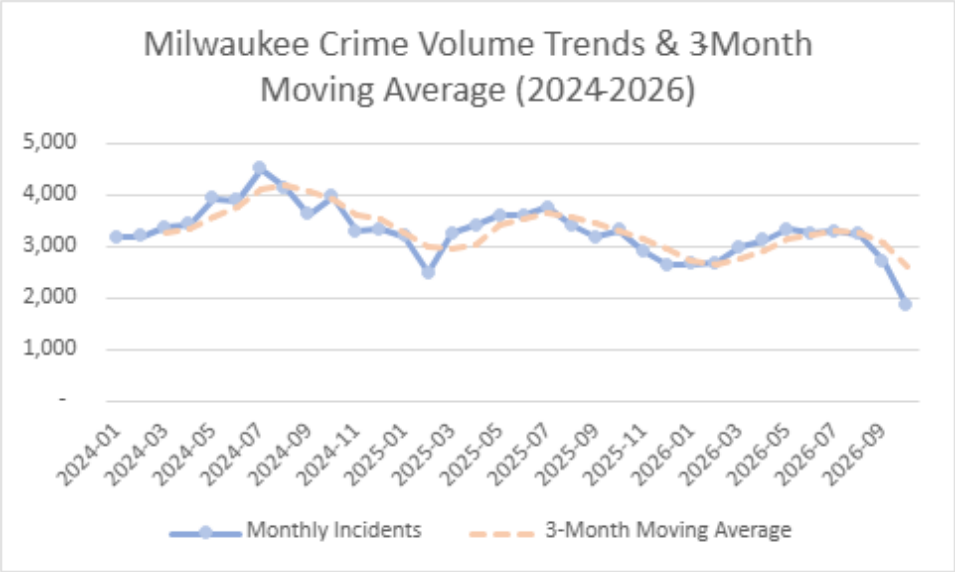
### Key Takeaways:

- **The Evening Shift Strain:** 2nd shift handles over 41% of all citywide calls. Officers spend almost their entire shift running from call to call, leaving little time for proactive neighborhood patrols.

- **The Midnight Call Spikes:** The single busiest hour of the whole day is 12:00 AM (Midnight), accounting for 9.57% of all calls (10,746 incidents). This surge hits right when 2nd shift is trying to hand off to 3rd shift, creating long wait times for non-emergency calls.

## Yearly Trends & Summer Call Surges

Crime volume follows a clear, predictable pattern throughout the year:




- **Winter Lows (Jan-Feb):** Cold weather keeps calls at their lowest point
- **Spring Build-up (Apr-May):** As warm weather returns, calls rise about 8% each month.
- **Summer Peak (July):** Calls hit their highest point in July, a 58% increase over winter levels.
- **Staffing Impact:** Officers often take summer vacations during July and August, which means there are fewer officers on duty when calls hit their highest point.

## Action Plan & Staffing Recommendations

### Add a 6:00 PM - 2:00 AM "Power Shift"

Instead of sticking to three rigid shifts, create an overlapping shift running from 6:00 PM to 2:00 AM. This puts extra squad cars on the street to absorb evening rush and cover the midnight surge without needing overtime.

### Adjust Officer Staffing Ratios (Based on 100 Officers)

If we look at a sample team of 100 officers, here is how we should assign them to match actual workload:

| Shift | Old Staffing | Recommended Staffing | Change |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1st Shift (8 AM - 4 PM) | 33 Officers | 26 Officers | -7 |
| 2nd Shift (4 PM - Midnight) | 34 Officers | 34 Officers | 0 |
| Power Shift (6 PM - 2 AM) | 0 Officers | 18 Officers | +18 |
| 3rd Shift (Midnight- 8 AM) | 33 Officers | 22 Officers | -11 |

### Smart Street Tactics

- 15-Minute Hotspot Stops: Have power shift officers spend 15 minutes at a time parked in high-crime blocks during slow moments. Research shows brief, visible police presence deters crime without displacing it.
- Better Lighting: Add temporary LED light towers in dark alleys and hot spots.
- Rolling Handovers: Have supervisors hand off duties in the field rather than at the station so street coverage doesn't drop between 11:30 PM and 1:30 AM.